

THE TORN PARTS OF SETH: A Consequence of a Dramatic Revenge

أشلاء جسد المعبود ست: نتيجة الانتقام الدرامي

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Abstract:

The paper discusses one of the most dramatic consequences in the famous myth of Horus and Seth. During their struggle, terrible actions were taken against the bodies of both gods, which ended with the triumph of Horus. Nevertheless, whether Seth was an evil deity or not, his corpse was treated severely, just as he did to the body of his brother Osiris. Some of his body parts were injured and torn out during the incidents of this fight, in his different animal forms. Many studies focused on the organs of the god Osiris, which were dispersed throughout the land of Egypt, and the efforts done by Isis to recollect them in order to revive her husband back, but a few tackled Seth's organs. The current paper sheds light on the fate of Seth. It makes a comparative analysis through the different religious texts and the rituals to know how the corpse of Seth was tortured into parts, what were the similarities and the differences between the fates of Osiris and Seth, the different methods used, and the different manifestations of Seth that faced this fate of killing and torturing. It finally presents three similar steps in both myths to gain a better insight into the consciousness and mindset of the ancient Egyptians about the death of deities.

Keywords: Seth, body parts, Horus, Pyramid Text, Edfou, Torture.

المخلص:

تتناول الدراسة أحد نتائج الصراع بين الإله حورس والإله ست. لقد قام حورس انتقاماً لمقتل أبيه أوزيريس من قاتله ست بالصراع معه، وقد تناولت العديد من النصوص قصة هذا الصراع، وما حدث للإلهين من إصابات. ولم يتم التركيز كثيراً على ما واجهه ست ورموزه من إصابات. يري الباحث أن هناك كثير من المشابهة والمقاربة بين ما حدث لجسد أوزير من تقطيعه إلى أجزاء، وما حدث لست أيضاً من تقطيع لجسده إلى أجزاء عن طريق حورس انتقاماً لوالده. وقد نجد أن كثيراً من أحداث القصتين متشابهتان، وذلك مع اختلاف النتائج والتفاصيل، ويتناول البحث الهيئات المختلفة المرتبطة بالإله ست التي نزل عليها هذا الانتقام، وإنزال العقاب على صور وهيئات الإله المختلفة، واتخذ هذا العقاب ثلاثة مراحل أساسية فهي تقع على رموز ست التي كان يتركز عليها، المرحلة الأولى، عملية القتل أو الصيد للهيئات المختلفة لست: كفرس النهر، والتمساح، والسلحفاة، والخنزير، والغزال. والمرحلة الثانية وهي مرحلة تقطيع أجزاء الإله ست بواسطة السكين، وخاصة أن ما يقوم به هو الجزاء بالسكين، المرحلة الثالثة وهي تقديمه في النهاية كنوع من أنواع القرابين المعروفة عند المصري القديم، ومن ثم كان يقام احتفالاً سنوياً في معبد إدفو بتحقيق النصر والانتقام إرضاء للإله أوزير.

الكلمات الدالة: ست، أجزاء الجسد، حورس، نصوص الأهرامات، متون التوابيت، أدفو، دندرة، فرس النهر، تقطيع.

1. Introduction

Seth was known from the Pre-dynastic periods¹ as the deity that embodied the forces of disturbance, being ill tempered and personifying anger, rage, and violence, the darker side of creation, and the contrast of the harmony of *maat*².

Born of the goddess Nut, Seth was the brother of Osiris, Isis, and Nephthys, as well as the husband of Nephthys³. He was jealous of his brother Osiris, the king of Egypt, that led to the murder of his brother Osiris and to contested the kingship of Egypt with Osiris's son and heir, Horus⁴.

Seth was portrayed in both zoomorphic and bimorphic forms. In his zoomorphic form, he was a canine-like creature with an erected tail, upright squared-off ears, and a down-curved nose; in his bimorphic form, he was a male human with the head of the Seth animal. He was depicted as an ass or with a human body and an ass's head during the Ptolemaic period⁵.

Several studies were conducted on Seth, with the most important being that of TeVelde, H., who gave a detailed study about the murder of Osiris by his brother Seth and what followed in torturing the body of Osiris⁶.

Some studies related what happened to Osiris by Seth to a natural phenomenon that happened annually in Egypt, that was the inundation of the river Nile, which caused a great damage and disorder to the earth (personified by Osiris) and the plants that were damaged and harmed.

The heir of Osiris, Horus had a very long conflict with Seth that reflects its course to the king to achieve the success of Horus in this struggle according to the famous myth⁷.

¹ Te Velde, Hermann, *Seth, The God of Confusion, A Study of his Role in Egyptian Mythology and Religion*, Leiden, E.J. Brill, 1967, 107.

² Leitz, Christian, "ḳtS" in *LGG VI*, 2002, 691ff; Hornung, Erik, *Conceptions of God in Ancient Egypt, The One and The Many*, Ithaca, New York, Cornell University Press, 1971, 103.

³ Te Velde, Hermann, "Seth", *LÄ V*, 1984, 908-911; TeVelde, "Horus und Seth", *LÄ III*, 1980, 26; TeVelde, *Seth, The God of Confusion*, 27-81; Pinch, Geraldine, *Handbook of Egyptian Mythology*, England 2002, 191.

⁴ Newberry, Percy, *The Set Rebellion of the 2nd Dynasty*, 1922, 40-46; Hornblower, G.D., *The Golden Horus*, *JEA* 24(1), 1938, 129; Griffiths, Gwyn, *The Conflict of Horus and Seth from Egyptian and Classical Sources, Liverpool monographs in archaeology and Oriental studies* 4, Liverpool University Press 1960; Taylor, Ian Robert, *Deconstructing the Iconography of Seth*, Phd Thesis, University of Birmingham 2016, 9ff.

⁵ Griffiths, *The Conflict of Horus and Seth*, 1960; Robert, Oden, *The Contendings of Horus and Seth*, (Chester Beatty Papyrus No.1), A Structural Interpretation, The University of Chicago Press 1979.

⁶ TeVelde, *Seth, The God of Confusion*, 107.

⁷ Gaudard, F., *The Demotic Drama of Horus and Seth*, Chicago, The University of Chicago, 2005; Simpson, William Kelly, (ed.), *The Literature of Ancient Egypt, An Anthology of Stories, Instructions, and Poetry*, Yale University Press 2003, 117-8; Morgan, Mogg, *The Bull of Ombos, Seth & Egyptian Magick II*, Mandrake of Oxford, 2005, 309.

So, at the Temple of Edfou, there were annual dramatic plays in which the triumph of Horus of Behdet over his enemies, his coronation as king of Upper and Lower Egypt were enacted⁸.

2. The Murder of Osiris by Seth:

The ancient Egyptian religious texts did not contain many details or a clear narrative of the murder of Osiris by Seth⁹, but hints were given, direct and indirect to Seth attacking Osiris¹⁰, as in the following:



Ni.n sw sn.f stš hr gs.f

“His brother Seth has thrown him on his side”¹¹

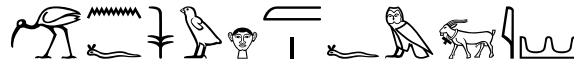
The corpse of Osiris was thrown on his side in the city of *Nedit*¹².



dd mdw hr r.f ti wr pw hr gs.f ndi r.f imi Ndit

“The great one who was found on his side in Nedit”¹³

Horus found his father lying down in the place of *Ghsty*¹⁴.



Gm.n.f sw (Osiris) hr gs.f m Ghsty

“He (Horus) found him on his side in the city of Gehsty”¹⁵

⁸ Blackman, Aylward, M.& Fairman, H.M, The Myth of Horus at Edfu II, The Triumph of Horus over his Enemies, A Sacred Drama, *JEA* 28, 1942, 32.

⁹ In the Greco Roman Temples as in the Temple of Edfou in the chamber of Osiris (room H) the complete myth of Osiris and his resurrection inscribed on the wall, See: Cauville, Silvie, *La Théologie d' Osiris à Edfou*, Le Caire, IFAO 1983, 25; E I, 204, 13-14.

¹⁰ Pyr.1544 a, b, c, d;1339a;1337b; Faulkner, Raymond, *The Ancient Egyptian Pyramid Texts*, Oxford, Clarendon Press 1969, 234-235.

¹¹ *rdi Hr gs* means “Throw on the side”, it is an expression for murder, See: Faulkner, Raymond, *A Concise Dictionary of Middle Egyptian*, Oxford,1964, 291; Lurker, Manfred, *The Deities and Symbols of Ancient Egypt*, New York, 1980, 93.

¹² Mercer, Samuel, *The Pyramid Texts in Translation and Commentary*, London Longmans, Green and Co. 1952, Utterance 482, 1008c, 278.

¹³ Pyr.819 a; Faulkner, Raymond, *The Ancient Egyptian Pyramid Texts*, Oxford, Clarendon Press 1969,147.

¹⁴ Pyr. 438, § 1799 a-b; Faulkner, *The Pyramid Texts*, 263.

¹⁵ GHsty is the Antelope Province, which may be the current Qmir in Upper Egypt. It was referred to by Gardiner as the murder place of the god Osiris. Additionally, it became the cult

Another interpretation of killing Osiris by his brother could be related to the nature of the phenomenon; every year, Seth symbolized the inundation of destructive and killing power that killed Osiris (the earth). Some paragraphs in the pyramids confirmed this idea, as in the following paragraph:



hwi.s.tw m 3g n ʿ n stš

“offering protects you (Osiris) from the (mutilation) flood of Seth’s hand”¹⁶

In this sentence, the word flood refers to the Nile flood, which is sometimes connected to the hate of Seth towards his brother Osiris, the god of Earth. After the flood receded, Osiris’s death and resurrection were celebrated with ten days plowing and planting ceremony called the “*Osirian festival of Khoiak*”¹⁷. Osiris's death here does not seem natural to the Nile god, but it is a disorderly death caused by Seth, who was known for his violent actions.

The tool used for killing Osiris was the knife used to cut him into pieces¹⁸, as in the following example from the Pyramid Texts¹⁹:



mds pri m stš

"The sharp knife that came from Seth"

This interpretation came from the myth of Osiris, where Seth killed his older brother twice. In the first instance, where the flood (Seth) drowned earth (Osiris)²¹, and Osiris

place of the god Khnum and Nbt-Ht. See: Kamal El-deen, N., “The Site of *Nedit* and its Importance in the Ancient Egyptian Religion”, in: The Seventeenth Conference Book of the General Union of Arab Archaeologists, Cairo 2014, 224-236; Sadek EL-Araby, “The Murder Place of Osiris GHsty and Ndit “A Comparative Study”, in: The Nintenth Conference Book of the General Union of Arab Archaeologists, Cairo 2016, 10-27.

Faulkner, Raymond, O., The Ancient Egyptian Coffin Texts, Utterance 478, § 972, 166; Mercer, *The Pyramid Texts*, Utterance 478, 972 b-c, 271, 272;

¹⁶ Pyr.20d; Faulkner, *Pyramid Texts*, 6; Pyr.1944a; Mercer, *The Pyramid Texts*, 413.

¹⁷ Chassinat, Émile, *Le Mystère d’Osiris au Mois de Khoiak*, Le Caire, IFAO 1968; Mikhail, L., *Dramatic Aspects of the Osirian Khoiak Festival, An Outline*, *GM* 81, 29-54.

The Osiris festival of *Khoiak* was introduced at the beginning of season *Peret* and began with a plowing and sowing ceremony, which was a symbol accorded to death: Meader, Jonathan & Demeter, Barbara, *Ancient Egyptian Symbols*, Done Yesterday Press, 2016, 87.

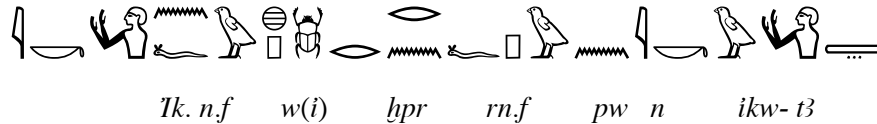
It is recorded in Dendera, Edfou, and Philae.

¹⁸ Assmann, Jan, *Death and Salvation in Ancient Egypt*, USA, 2005, 68.

¹⁹ Pyr.1999c.

symbolized the fertile land²⁰, which was covered by the inundation flood ²¹for four months. It was also referred to as the revenge of Horus, from the one who slaughtered his father²², and his organs which symbolized plowing the soil. Therefore, Osiris was called in the Book of the Dead²³ *ist* "he was cut" ²⁴.

Osiris complained Seth to the Ennead because he attacked him, and the earth was attacked as well²⁵.



“It was he who attacked me when there came into being this his name of earth attacker”.

2.1 The Torn Parts of the God Osiris:

According to the myth of Isis and Osiris, Seth killed his brother Osiris; then, he dispersed his body parts as the religious texts confirmed; such as the head, heart, neck, spine, legs, and genitalia (phallus) were all scattered in various places²⁶.

In the Pyramid Texts, there were references to the torn parts of Osiris, which Seth has scattered in many districts across Egypt²⁷. Plutarch said that the body of Osiris was torn into fourteen pieces (some say they were sixteen)²⁸.

²⁰ Pinch, Geraldine, *Egyptian Myth, A Very Short Introduction*, Oxford, Oxford University Press 2004, 58.

²¹ Meader, Jonathan & Demeter, Barbara, *Ancient Egyptian Symbols*, California, 2016, 86; Pyr. 20d.

²² Pyr. 1977b; Faulkner, *Pyramid Texts*, 285.

²³ Allen, George, *The Book of the Dead or Going by Day*, Chicago, The University of Chicago Press 1974, 5.

²⁴ Wb V, 330,5-11; Erman, Adolf & Grapow, Hermann, *Wörterbuch der Aegyptischen Sprache*, Berlin, Akademie Verlag 1971.

²⁵ Pyr.959 a, b; Mercer, *The Pyramid Texts*, 236.

²⁶ Coulon, Laurent, “Les Reliques d’Osiris en Égypte Ancienne: Données Générales et Particularismes des Cultes Thébains”, Borgeaud, P. & Volokhine, Y. (éds), *Les Objets de la Mémoire: Pour une Approche Comparatiste des Reliques et de leur Culte*, *Studia Religiosa Helvetica* 10-11, Peter Lang, Bern, 2005, 17-20.

²⁷ Pyr.645(a);835(a-c);1684(a-c)-1685(a).

²⁸ The body of the god Osiris was torn into fourteen parts that refer to the lunar circular and sometimes in the texts of Dendera they are sixteen parts. It may be connected to the rise of the inundation as the ideal height was sixteen cubits. Sometimes it is forty-two parts that represent the provinces of Egypt, as the sentence:

inw n.k spAwt.k 42 iw.f .k pw means “I will bring to you the forty-two(42) provinces which are your limbs” refers to that, See:

Horus tried to gather these parts to mummify his father²⁹, but finally, Isis succeeded in finding the organs except for the phallus that was eaten by a catfish³⁰, and revive him back to life.

The first evidence talking about the deteriorated organs of Osiris could be found in the Chester Beatty Papyrus 10688 in the British Museum³¹ and the Jumilhac Papyrus in the Louvre Museum³². In the Canopic procession in the Temple of Dendera, the Osirian chapels (the eastern one), contain a group of gods carrying the organs of the god Osiris inside Canopic jars; each jar related to a governmental province, with a part of the body³³.

2.2 Avenging the Murder of Osiris by Horus:

The ancient texts did not mentioned clearly that Horus killed Seth as an act of revenge, but the apparent meaning of this act there is that a Sethian animal was killed in a sacrifice as argued by Griffiths³⁴. The Pyramid Texts contain several spells that describe the conflict between Horus and Seth³⁵, which Newberry proposed that the myth of that conflict in religious texts was in fact based on a historical event³⁶. During the struggle the god Horus used some weapons to stab the evil creature (the symbols of

Chassinat, Émile, *Le Mystère d'Osiris au Mois de Khoiak*, 195; Beinlich, Horst, *Die Osirisreliquien zum Motiv der körperzergliederung in der Altägyptischen Religion*, ÄA 42, Wiesbaden, 1984, 208; Dümichen, Johannes, & Brugsch, Heinrich, *Recueil De Monuments Égyptiens: Geographische Inschriften Altägyptischer Denkmäler: an Ort und Stelle Gesammelt und mit Übersetzung und Erläuterungen, Dritte Abtheilung*, Leipzig, J.C. Hinrich's Buchhandlung 1885, Taf. 42.

²⁹Pantalacci, Laure, *Rescherches sur Osiris Démembré*, Thèse de Doctorat de IIIe Cycle, Université de Paris, Sorbonne 1981; Id., *Une Conception Originale de la Survie Osirienne d'Après les Textes de Basse Époque*, GM 52, 1981, 57-66

³⁰ Griffiths, J., *Plutarch's De Iside et Osiride*, Oxford 1970, 52-53; Beinlich, *Osirisreliquien zum Motiv der körperzergliederung*, 220-221.

³¹ Gardiner, Alan H., and Litt, D., *Hieratic Papyri in the British Museum, Third Series: Chester Beatty Gift*, vol. 1: Text, London, Trustees of the British Museum 1935, 66; Herman, J. de Meulenaere, "Papyrus Brooklyn", LÄ IV, 1982, 694; Coulon, Laurent, "Le Tombeau d'Osiris à Travers les Textes Magiques du Nouvel Empire", Gallois, Chr. Grandet, P. et Pantalacci, Laure, (éds), *Mélanges Offerts à Francois Neveu par ses Amis, Élèves et Collègues à l'Occasion de son Soixante-Quinzième Anniversaire*, BdE 145, Le Caire, IFAO 2008, 76.

³² Vandier, Jacques, *Le Papyrus Jumilhac*, Paris, Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique 1971.

³³ Beinlich, Horst, "Zur Deutung der Sogenannten Osirisreliquien", GM 54, 1982, 17, 19.

³⁴ Pyr.1977b; 643b; Griffiths, *The Conflict of Horus and Seth*, 5.

³⁵ Mathieu, Bernard, *Seth Polymorphe: le Rival, le Vaincu, l'Auxiliaire*, Montpellier, Université Paul Valéry, Montpellier III, 2011, 143; Pyr.819 a; Pyr.442; Faulkner, *Pyramid Texts*, 147.

³⁶ Griffiths, *The Conflict of Horus and Seth*, 1960; Robert, *The Contendings of Horus and Seth*, 1979.

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Seth), such as the knife, staves, bows, arrows, and a harpoon. The most important and widely used one was the harpoon. It was the most used weapon during the battle. The harpoon was made of a long stick of wood or metal with a sharp-pointed end. It was the most related to the killing of Seth, and it was one of the military weapons that were connected to the king's victories over his enemies, personifying chaos, his rebirth and resurrection³⁷. After a violent conflict, Horus succeeded in crushing both Seth and his followers and brought them to Osiris in a state of helplessness. In the Pyramid Texts, Horus says to his father Osiris:



i3d .tw m i3d k3

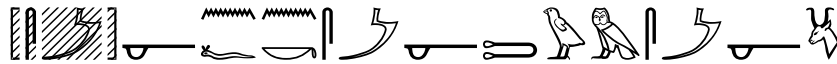
*"I have killed for you him who killed you as a wild bull"*³⁸



In n.k Hr stš di.n.f n.k sw ksi hr.k wr pht.k ir.f

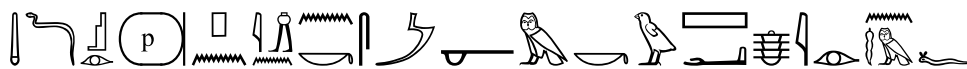
*"Horus has brought Seth to you he has given him to you bowed down under you, your strength is greater than his"*³⁹

and Osiris is addressed:



sm3.n.f n.k sm3.tw m sm3

*"He slew for you the one who slew you"*⁴⁰



dd mdw Wsir P pn in.n.k sm3.kwi š' iir ndm.f

*"words spoken by Osiris-king there is brought to you the one who slew you ..."*⁴¹

³⁷ Odler, Martin & Peterkova Hlouchova, Marie, Harpoons in the Ritual Context of the Old Kingdom, SAK 46, 2017, 191-222.

³⁸ Pyr.1545b; Sethe, Kurt, Die Altaegyptischen Pyramidentexte, 330.

³⁹ Pyr.1632a-b; 1285c; 597b-c.

⁴⁰ Pyr.1339a; 1977b.

⁴¹ Pyr.1339a

The castration of Seth as a hippopotamus was found in the Coffin Texts⁴².



Wd⁴³ pw s3 Nt hr hry gs.f nhm t3w.f

*“This Outcast; son of Nut falls on his side and his breath has been taken away”.*⁴⁴

Another paragraph from the Coffin Texts:



It.i Wsir mk wi ii.kwi hr.k hwi.i n.k wd^c sm3.n.i sm3yt.f iw hwi.n.i hwii tw kni.n.i knyw tw

*“O my father Osiris, here am I; I have come to you, for I have struck Seth for you, I have killed his followers for you, I have beaten who smote you, I have cut down who cut you down.”*⁴⁵

3. The Methods of Torturing the Parts of Seth:

In the myth of Osiris’s death, three major incidents happened, and the same three steps of violence were taken against Seth. The author sees a resemblance in these steps with regard to the differences in the circumstances and actions: (first) it was the hunting (killing) of the Sethian animals, (second) it was the cutting of the animal of Seth limbs into pieces, and (third) it was the contributing of the organs with different gods and places, to finally face a destined fate, as manifested in the rituals of triumph of Horus in the Greco-Roman temples.

3.1. The First Step: Hunting and Killing by the Harpoon:

In the Temple of Edfou, Horus used ten harpoons to kill and hunt the different manifestations of Seth in a harpoon ritual⁴⁶. The texts and scenes described every part of the body of the Sethian animal that the harpoon reached (**fig.1&2**). It is well known

⁴² TeVelde, Seth, The God of Confusion, 59.

⁴³ Referring to the god Seth, See: El Shamy, Saraa, “The Meaning of WDa in Coffin Texts”, *IJTHM* 5, 2022, 258-279.

⁴⁴ De Buck, Adrian, The Egyptian Coffin Texts, Vol.V,1961, 35 (Spell 373); Faulkner, Raymond, O., The Ancient Egyptian Coffin Texts, II,1977, 9-10; Carrier, Claude, Textes des Sarcophages du Moyen Empire Égyptien, Éditions du Rocher, II, Monaco 2004, 906-907.

⁴⁵ CT IV, 56 c-h.

⁴⁶ Chassinat, Émile, Le Temple d'Edfou III, PL. LXXII; Säve- Söderberg, On Egyptian Representations of Hippopotamus Hunting as a Religious Motive, Lund 1953, 26.

that, getting rid of evil started earlier, and the harpooning depictions first appeared on the archaic handles of knives, palettes, and Pottery dated to Naqada I, showing the mythical creatures defeated by the king or performed by Horus who defeated evil personified in the god Seth⁴⁷. The triumph of Horus over Seth could be seen in the

ideogram  (A251)⁴⁸, and Horus himself in another ideogram in the sign . This was a reference to the god “Horus Behditite”, or “Horus of Mesen”⁴⁹, and this depiction was specified by the signs C71, 72,73, A251. It appears repeatedly in the Temple of Edfou by the sign  (C73) as an image of Horus Behditite stabbing the crocodile with a harpoon in its head⁵⁰, as well as with this form specified by the sign  (C72), and the sign  (C71)⁵¹,  (C71A)⁵², the same sign is depicted in the Temple of Dendera⁵³.

The ritual of harpooning the hippopotamus suggested that Seth was easily defeated by the king, who was the heir of Horus over the throne of Egypt. Horus Behditite was shown in his boat holding his harpoon(**fig.1**), while Seth transformed himself into a hippopotamus and his followers into crocodiles and at Elephantine Horus defeated

⁴⁷ Maydana, Sebastian, Hippopotamus hunting in Predynastic Egypt: Reassessing Archaeozoological evidence, *Archaeofauna* 29, Madrid 2020,137.-150.
<http://doi.org/10.15366/archaeofauna2020.29.009>

⁴⁸ iAwty was an epithet of Horus of Behdet, it was also the Horus aspect of the king. In origin it may derive from iAAt “stave”; thus, it means “the holder of the stave” = harpoon. See: Barta, Winfried, “Horus von Edfu”, *LÄ III*, 34 n.16. Other deities appeared with a harpoon. For instance, the god *Wenty* was one of the deities who associated with a harpoon. He was worshipped in Abydos, Mendes, and Busiris and also associated with the magical texts and Horus of Edfou was also referred to as *Horus-Wenty*, See: Arafa, Nagwa, “Enquête sur le Dieu *Ounty*”, *ARCE* 47, Cairo 2011, 259-278.

⁴⁹ From the Old Kingdom onward Horus the Behdetite is often describes as nb Msn “Lord of Mesen” The word Msn is usually has a the sign of the city for a determinative, which indicates it is a toponym. The name is designated to Edfou and a few cities in the Delta and with Lower Egypt. The name of the city, however, derives from a word associated with harpooning. During the first few dynasties of Egypt there is a Horus falcon, which appears with a harpoon and is often referred to as “Horus the Harpooner” This deity seems to be the early form of “Horus Lord of Mesen”, for more informations, See: Shonkwiler, Randy, *The Behdetite: A Study of Horus the Behdetite from the Old Kingdom to The Conquest of Alexander*, Chicago, Oriental Institute of Chicago, 2014, 313;

⁵⁰ Horus was first depicted holding a harpoon on Narmer Palette, See: Quibell, James, Esward, Hierakonpolis I: Plates of Discoveries in 1898, *BSAE* 4, London: Bernard Quaritch, 1900, pl. 29; E III, 88, 13.

⁵¹ E IV, 58,4; IV, 59, 8.

⁵² E VI, 110,111.

⁵³ D X, 271,4.

them⁵⁴. This myth comprises the scenes of Horus harpooning Seth forms representing crocodile and hippopotamus⁵⁵. Horus was also depicted on the southern wall of the Hibis Temple in human form with a falcon head and human arms, while the rear part of the bird was standing on the crocodile and harpooning it and holding an *ankh*-sign in his other hand⁵⁶.

3.2. The Torn Parts of the Incarnations of Seth through Religious Texts and Rituals:

Seth was described more than once in the Pyramid Texts as being slain in the form of a bull; the same association was prominent in the spells of the funerary rituals⁵⁷. He was also slain and injured in his different forms, including antelope, pig, hippopotamus, tortoise, crocodile, and ass.

In the Temple of Edfou, there are two boats (**fig.1**). In the first boat, Horus, “lord of Mesen”, armed with a harpoon and rope, pierces a hippopotamus in the neck. In the second, Horus of Behdet, is similarly armed and wounds the head of a hippopotamus. Therefore, these rituals of killing Sethian animals’ bodies were injured, as in the following rituals:

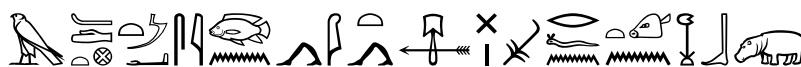
3.2. In Rituals:

3.2a Harpooning the Nose and the Head of a Hippopotamus:



M fnd.f fdḳ.n.f šrtj.f ndri bi3 m tp n h3b hnt st mh-ib

“The (harpoon) is stucked in his nose (=Seth), it tears out the openings of his nose, the blade from copper is in the head of the hippopotamus where you desire”⁵⁸



Hr Bhdt m3^c s int sti r.f n šrt n h3bs

“Horus the Behditite his harpoon is in the nose of the hippopotamus”

⁵⁴ Ritner, Robert, “Horus on the Crocodiles: A Juncture of Religion and Magic in Late Dynastic Egypt”, Simpson, W., (ed.), *Religion and Philosophy in Ancient Egypt*, New Haven, Yale Egyptological Seminar, 1989, 103-116; Cruz-Uribe, Eugene, “stx aA pHty”, Seth, God of Power and Might, *JARCE* 45, 2009, 208.

⁵⁵ Säve-Söderbergh, On Egyptian Representations of Hippopotamus Hunting, 26.

⁵⁶ László, Kákósy, Selected Papers 1956-1973, *Studia Aegyptiaca VII*, Budapest 1981

⁵⁷ Pyr.1007a;1543a;1976a;418a

⁵⁸ E VI, 64, 3.

3.2.b Harpooning the Nose of a Hippopotamus and the Tongue of a Bull:



*dd mdw in Hr Bhdty ntr 3 nb pt nb Msn ndriw ury-h3t m h3t.f sty.n.f m^cb3.f r fnd n h3b
mwt.f 3st m gs dpt.f*

“Words spoken by Horus the Behditie the great god lord of Edfou, the hunter, the sailor in his military boat who throws his harpoon and pushes it into the nose of h3b =of Seth while his mother Isis is beside his boat”⁵⁹

The tongue was given as a gift to the harpooners who were as followers of Horus during his battle with Seth in their vessels, as Isis says:

“Give his tongue to the Young Harpooners”

3.2.c Harpooning the Hinder Part of a Hippopotamus:

The eighth harpoon is stuck fast in his hind quarter; it has ripped up his haunches:



In.tw.k phwy n db nht n m3i hs3

“You seize the hinder part of the hippopotamus by the strength of the furious lion”⁶⁰

3.3 The Second Step: Slaying and Cutting with the Knife (fig.5):

Slaying the animal of Seth with a knife was depicted in the offering rituals on the walls of the Greco-Roman temples, for example in the Temple of Dendera, a scene represents the slaughtering of the animal of Seth in the form of a bull, with the body torn into pieces by the butcher’s knife⁶¹, while the *Sem*-priest stood behind him reciting the ritual (**fig.3&4**). The offering ritual in the form of the parts of Seth was a metaphor for success and the cutting of the animal in front of Osiris is intended to satisfy him as the offerings represent the parts of his enemy and killer Seth. The idea of torturing the body of Seth showed the revenge that the son Horus made for

⁵⁹ E VI, 81, 9; I,14 (14)

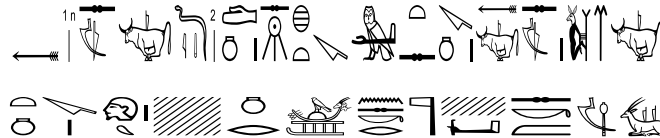
⁶⁰ E VI, 87 (4).

⁶¹ mnHw “butchers, slaughters” see: Wilson, Penelope, A Ptolemaic Lexikon, A Lexicographical Study of the Texts in the Temple of Edfu, OLA 78, Leuven 1997, 433; Zandee, Jan, *Death as an Enemy: According to Ancient Egyptian Conceptions*, New York, Areno Press, a New York Company 1977, 200; Wb II, 84, 2; Dendara VI, 36, 2.

his father, and the torturing organs of Seth nearly the same as those of the god Osiris.

3.3.a Slaying the Head of a Gazelle (fig. 6,7):

The killing of “the slaughtered animal- *sm3*” as Seth's incarnation is evident in many texts from the Temple of Edfou. The king brings the gazelle in front of Horus and says:



*Sm3 sm3 ḏd mdw šsp.n.i s3ḥt mds.n.i šsr sm3.i sby m sm3 dn.i tp.f ḥnw n Skr [mḏḥ]
isk m m3-ḥd.*

“Slaying the bull:recitation: I receive the knife and slay the bull and the enemy(Seth) with the bull and tear his head, while the barque of Soker is ornamented with the white gazelle”

3.3.b Slaying the Leg of a Bull:

The Ramesseum Dramatic Papyrus it refers to the cutting of the front leg of Seth ⁶²in the Struggle.

“O Osiris the king, take the foreleg of Seth which Horus has torn off...”⁶³



iw Hr di h3w.f iw.f š3^c ḥpš.f iw.f ...

“Horus hurried to cut his foreleg of (Seth)”⁶⁴

A unique scene in the Temple of Dendera (figs.3&4), shows the bull of the god Seth, being cut out, and his foreleg is given to Osiris in the ritual of opening the mouth⁶⁵. Behind him are two goddesses, *Hatmehyt* and another goddess perhaps *Weret-hekaw*.

⁶² In the Ramesseum Dramatic Papyrus Section 108; the details are drawn from the bull-sacrifice which is so often linked with Seth Griffiths, *The Conflict, Horus and Seth*, 35.

⁶³ Pyr.42 Utterance 61.

⁶⁴ E VI, 222

⁶⁵ Otto, Eberhard, “Das Ägyptische Mundöffnungritual”, I, *ÄA* 3, Wiesbaden, Otto Harrassowitz, 1960, 44-51, 96-101; II, 14-15, 73-78, 102-105.

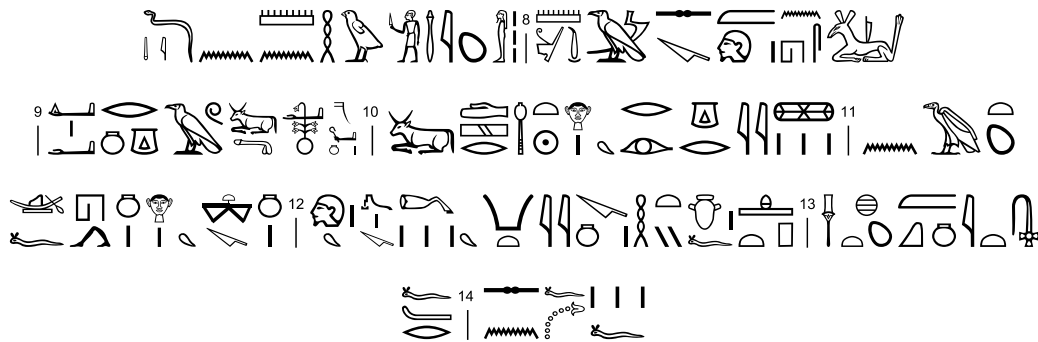
THE TORN PARTS OF SETH: A Consequence of a Dramatic Revenge

In the second register are *Isis* and *Harsaisis*⁶⁶. *Hatmehyt* played a role in searching for the organs of her brother Osiris, as she played the role of his sister⁶⁷

3.3.c Slaying the Heart and the Head of a Bull:

In Dendera, another unique scene of the bull being cut out and his heart is given to

the god Osiris in the ritual of opening the mouth⁶⁸(fig.3)



*dd mdw in mnḥw ʕ irw mn m3s m tp Nhs di ʕ r ng3w šmʕ ḥwi.n.i iḥ dsr
ḥd.i ḥr.f r irt ḥrwt n mwt im.f ḥ3.n.i ḥr.f wdʕ.n.i tp.f stp.i ḥpšw.f šdy.n.i
ḥ3ty.f ḥtp šḥmt m knt.f ḥnʕ snf.f*

“words spoken by the butcher great of shapes who put the knife on the head of
Nehes=Seth, who slay the southern bull I hit the red bull and cut his head for offerings
for Mut by him I tremble over him and cut his head and his legs and tear his heart to
satisfy Sekhmet by his fats and blood”⁶⁹

3.3.d Slaying the Testicles of a Bull⁷⁰

In the Pyramid Texts:



In n stš N mr.f sw in n.f N ḥrw.f

“The king who has brought back to him (Seth) his testicles”⁷¹



⁶⁶ Dendara X, 22.

⁶⁷ Dendara I, 127, 9; Dendara X, 23.

⁶⁸ Otto, Mundöffnungritual I, 44-51,96-101; II, 14-15, 73-78, 102-105.

⁶⁹ Dendara X, 53 (11-14).

⁷⁰ Pinch, Geraldine, *Egyptian Mythology*, 2004, 82-83, 91; TeVelde, Seth, The God of Confusion, 1967, 43-46, 58.

⁷¹ Pyr.535 a-b

hr hr n irt.f sb n k3 n hrw.f

“Horus has fallen down because of his eye⁷², the bull (Seth) has rolled down because of his testicles” fall! Roll down!⁷³

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Horus is seen thrusting the seventh harpoon into the testicles of the hippopotamus⁷⁹. The text reads:



sb3w Msn in Hr s3 3st isw stš m ʿf htp Bḥdt

“The doors of Edfou (are opened) by Horus son of Isis as the testicles of Seth are in his hand and Edfou is satisfied”



mʿb3 7 mn m ht.f mhy.n.f m3ʿtyw.f

*“The seventh harpoon is struck fast in his body and hath spiked? his testicles”*⁸⁰

3.3.e Slaying the Hands (fingers) of Seth:

A spell from the Pyramid Texts relate to the fingers of Seth:

*“O Osiris the king, take the finger of Seth which causes the white eye of Horus to see”*⁸¹

From all the previous examples of rituals, one may conclude that the killing and cutting the body of a Sethian animal which was related to a sacrifice for offerings is a net metaphoric action for revenge from Seth as he had done to Osiris. In table (1), the author gives an approximate resemblance between the injured parts of the bodies of Seth and those of Osiris.

Table 1: The parts of Seth in his animal forms with references to those of Osiris:

Parts	Form	Source	References to Osiris'Organs
- Head (<i>tp</i>)	Gazelle-Hippopotamus	E VI,81,9; E I,14 (14)	Coulon, L. “Les reliques d’Osiris en Égypte ancienne”, 27
- Front Leg (foreleg) (<i>hpš</i>)	Bull	Dendera X, 53; E VI, 222	Left leg and right leg Chassinat, É., Le Temple D'Edfou,

⁷⁹ E I, 346.

⁸⁰ In the Ramesseum Dramatic Papyrus, the mutilated testicles of Seth appear to be represented by two scepters, See: Griffiths, The Conflict of Horus and Seth, 34; Ramesseum Dramatic Papyrus, 83-86 and scene 17, pl.18; Blackman, Aylward & Fairman, Walter, The Myth of Horus at Edfou II, *JEA* 29,1943,14; E XIII, pl. DIV; E VI,75,1

⁸¹ Pyr.48, Utt.69.

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			première partie (Textes), MIFAO 10, 338.
- Heart (<i>ib</i>)	Bull	Ritual of removing the heart of the bull Dendera X, 53	CT I, spell 314, 236.
-Testicles (<i>drw</i>)	Bull+Hippopotamus	Pyr.535 a; E I, 346	The Phallus Gardiner, A. H., Hieratic Papyri in the British Museum, 74, vs. 6, 10
- Neck (<i>i3t</i>)	Bull	Cut the neck of the bull Dendera X, 53	Brugsch, H., Dictionnaire Géographique, 26
- Hinderpart	Hippopotamus	Chapter 134 of the Book of the Dead	Gardiner, A. H., Hieratic Papyri in the British Museum, 74, vs. 6, 10.
- Backbone (<i>psd</i>)	-Hippopotamus	The sixth harpoon was planted and separated from the backbone of the hippo.	Gauthier, H., Dictionnaire Géographiques III, 85.
- Fingers (<i>dbꜥw</i>)	-	Pyr.48, Utt.69	The hands Coulon, L., “Le Tombeau d’Osiris”, 72
-Thigh		Ramesseum Dramatic Papyrus ⁸²	
-Other parts	Fats-Bones-Liver		Duemichen, J., & Brugsch, H., Geographische Inschriften: Tempel von Edfu, 1; De Rougé, J., Géographie Ancienne de La Basse- Égypte, Paris, 1891, 13.

4. Third Step: Contributing the Parts of Seth as Offerings:

⁸² Geisen, Christina, The Ramesseum Dramatic Papyrus, A New Edition, Translation, and Interpretation, PhD Thesis, University of Toronto 2012, 291.

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While the organs of the body of Osiris were preserved inside sacred containers to be guarded as holy organs, the organs of Seth were contributed as offerings to different gods, while some parts were either burnt in braziers, or given as food for dogs and wolves⁸³.

The scenes of cutting out the organs of Seth in his animal form happened in front of Osiris; then, the organs were offered to him directly in the presence of Isis or one of the protective goddesses, and also his son Horus to satisfy Osiris and prove that the dismembering of the organs of Seth was intended to be a revenge as a result of what he did to Osiris from dismembering and scattering his limbs⁸⁴.

Seth has faced the same fate of dismembering his body, his organs were scattered in different places, and the final step was offering his limbs as offerings to the different gods, while the rest were burnt in braziers⁸⁵, or given as food to the dogs and worms.

Finally, Isis advised her son Horus to send every part to a different gods and places across Egypt. Furthermore, she advised Horus to assume the White Crown and the kingly office of his father Osiris.

Table 2 Contributing the parts of Seth as offerings for different deities:

Parts	Deity	Place
- Foreleg	Osiris-Onnophris	Busiris
- Heart	Horus	Edfou
-Shank	Onuris	Thinis=Abydos
- Shoulder	Thoth&Wepwawt	Hermopolis Magna (Yapt) ⁸⁶
- Shank	Ipy-sehedj ⁸⁷	Dep
- Ribs	Haroeris	Letopolis
- Breast	Hare-Goddess	Not specified
- Neck	Wadjet	Buto
- Liver	Sepa	Heliopolis
- Chest	Tefnut	Asyut
- Great meat portion	Khnum	Elephantine
- Hinderpart& Forepart	Isis	Not specified

5. Conclusion:

⁸³ E III, 188, 8; D X, 118,12; 21.

⁸⁴ E V, 399, 2-3.

⁸⁵ Fairman, Walter, *The Triumph of Horus: An Ancient Egyptian Sacred Drama*. Berkeley: U.C. Press, 1974.

⁸⁶ Gauthier, Henri, *Dictionnaire des Noms Géographiques Contenus dans les Textes Hieroglyphique*, T.I, Le Caire 1925, 65.

⁸⁷ The title means “Who attributes light” a title of Osiris, not attested elsewhere than Edfou, see: Wilson, Penelope, *A Ptolemaic Lexikon*, Leuven, Peeters1997, 62.

From the previous study, it is to be concluded that there was a great similarity in actions taken during the murder of Osiris and that of Seth. Horus took three main steps to get an act of revenge on Seth which seems similar to what happened to his father as in his first act: it was the hunting with the harpoon of a Sethian animals, as hunting needs deceiving the prey just as Seth deceived Osiris to catch him to his death; In his second act, it was the cutting of the animal of Seth into pieces (just as the body of Osiris was cut into pieces); Finally, his third act was distributing the organs of Seth's animal to different gods and places (just as the parts of Osiris were distributed to different provinces all over the country).

From all the previous mentioned rituals that were made to get revenge on Seth, the animal was referred to by name not by referring to Seth. As, in most of the accompanying texts we read what happened to *nhs*, *h3b*, *k3*, and *sm3*, in the harpooning and cutting rituals. Therefore, one could conclude that the ancient Egyptians never thought or did killing a god, and the death of a god was very hateful, so they did the revenge metaphorically in Seth's animals as the bull, hippopotamus, and the oryx as a kind of sacrifice.

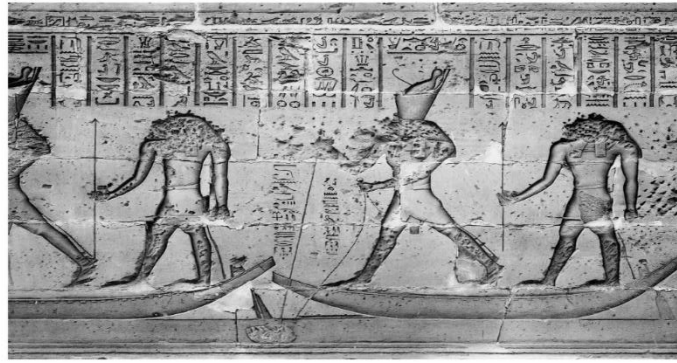
Finally, there is of course a difference in the myth of Osiris and Seth, but the author tried to visualize the thought of the ancient Egyptian in revenge by focusing on the most similar parts in texts, steps, and actions made towards Seth from hunting, cutting, dismembering as happened to Osiris. But the difference in the fate between the good and the evil by reviving Osiris and dismembering and burning for Seth. while Osiris aimed to obtain sacredness in some cities, Seth's organs were intended to be offerings to cause him weakness, decrease his strength, and prevent him from re-cutting the body of Osiris.

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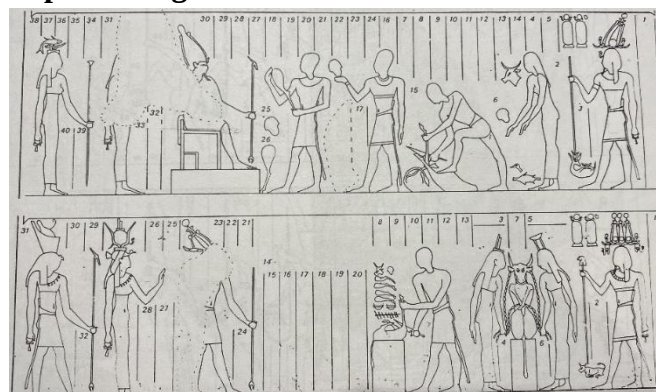
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(Figure 1) Horus in his Boat Harpooning Hippopotamus
Edfou XLII, pl. DIV



(Figure 2) Horus Standing over Hippopotamus-Temple of Edfou
<http://doi.org/10.15366/archaeofauna2020.29.009>



(Figure 3) Slaying the Parts of Seth by the butcher
Dendera X, 15,31



**(Figure 4) Slaying the Parts of Seth by the Butcher
Dendera X, 188**



**(Figure 5) Slaying a Hippopotamus by the Butcher
<https://images.app.goo.gl/XqR2HyDFjK2LeNB68>**



**(Figure 6) Dendera, pl. CCCCVIII
Ritual of Slaying the Gazelle by the King**



**(Figure 7) Ritual of Slaying the Gazelle by the King
Dendera, pl. DLXXI**